

CityTech TTP Summer Bootcamp

Interpreting and Communicating Data

2026-07-15

Agenda

1. Review
2. Follow-Ups
3. Reports and Dashboards
4. Interactive Charts with Plotly
5. Group Project

Review

What are the most important things you remember from yesterday?

Follow Up: Copying a DataFrame

Assigning a DataFrame does **not** copy it, unless you ask.

Copy by reference

```
df2 = df
df2["x"] = 0

# df changed too:
# one object, two names
```

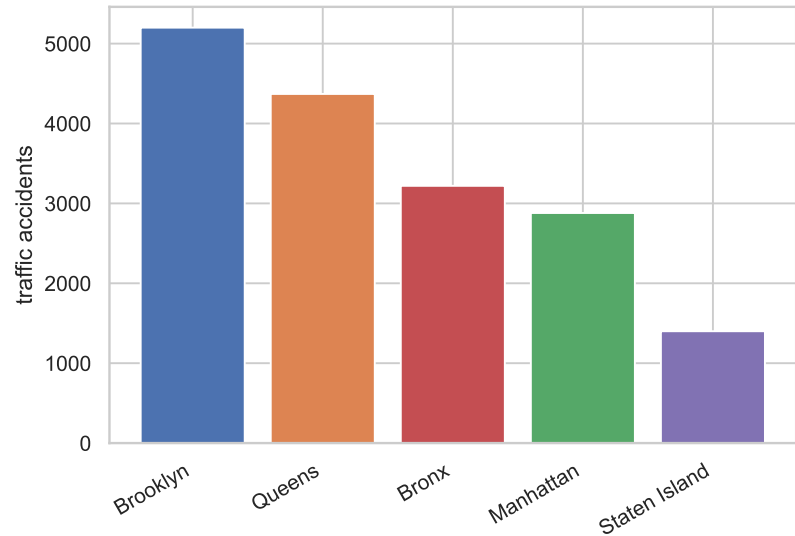
Copy by value

```
df3 = df.copy()
df3["x"] = 0

# df untouched:
# a separate object
```

Plain assignment is **by reference**. Use `.copy()` for an independent copy.

Follow Up: Absolute Numbers Can Mislead



(Invented data, not real.)

Brooklyn has the most accidents, nearly **4x** Staten Island.

So Brooklyn is the most dangerous borough.

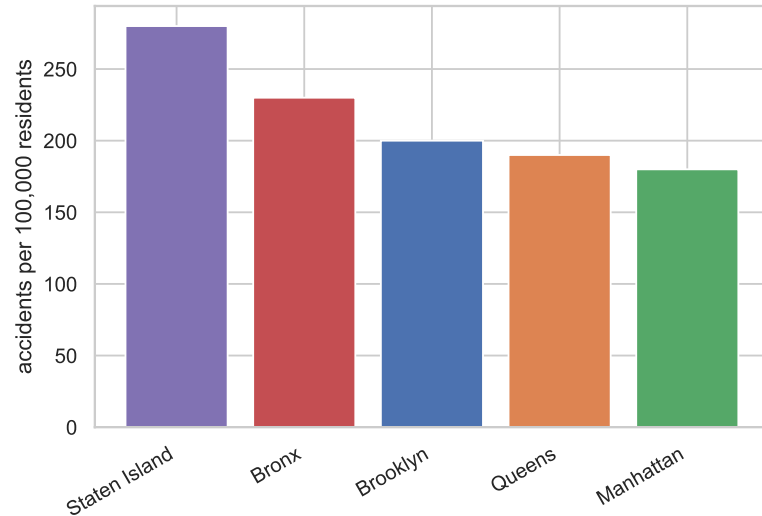
Case closed?

Bigger Groups Have Bigger Counts

Brooklyn has the most accidents because Brooklyn has the most **people**.

- A chart of **raw counts** is usually a chart of **how big each group is**
- A count answers "how many?", never "how risky?"
- The neighborhood with the most **311 complaints** may just be the one with the most **residents**
- Without a denominator, the count mostly reflects **group size**

One Solution: Divide by Population



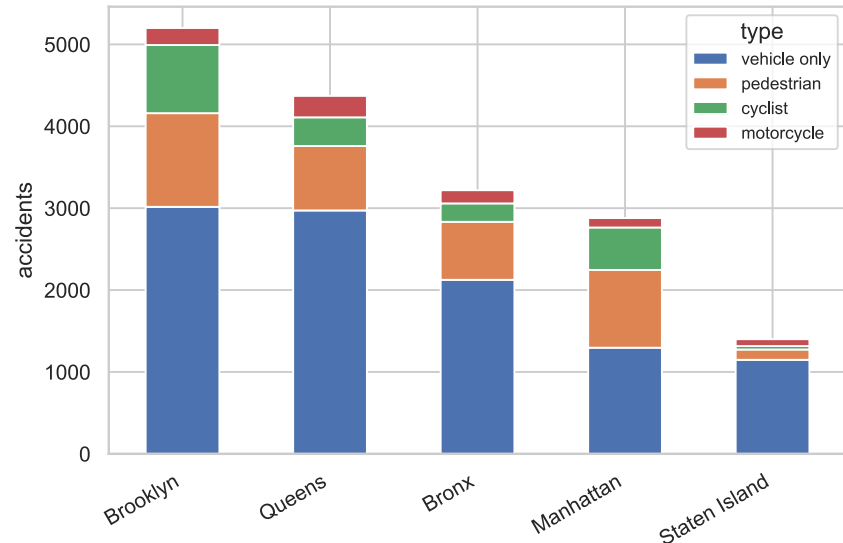
Per 100,000 residents answers "how risky?" The ranking **flips**:

- **Staten Island:** *last* by count, **first** by rate
- **Brooklyn:** *first* by count, only **third** by rate

```
df["per_100k"] = (  
    df["accidents"]  
    / df["population"] * 100_000  
)
```

(Invented data, not real.)

The Usual View: Stacked Counts

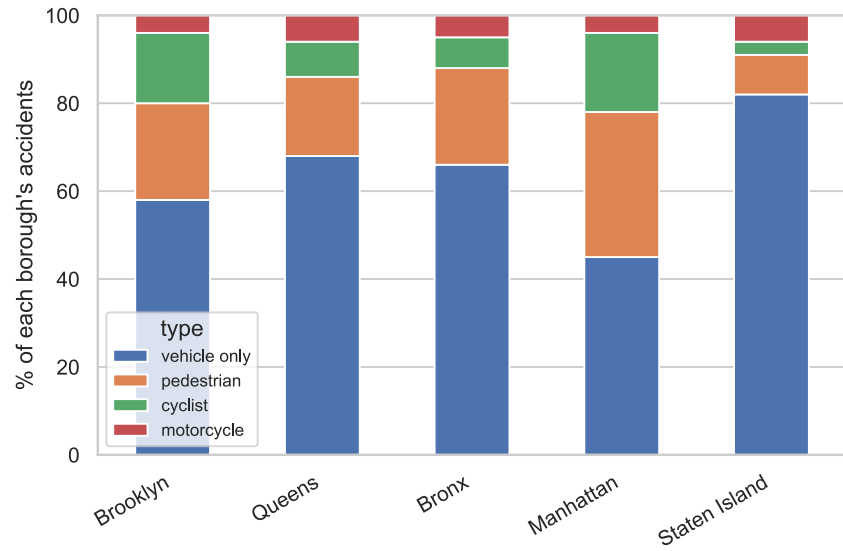


Break each borough's accidents down by **type**, as a stacked bar.

- Familiar, but the bars still track **borough size**
- Brooklyn's is tallest because Brooklyn is **biggest**, not because its mix differs
- Hard to compare the **mix** across boroughs

(Invented data, not real.)

A Second Solution: Percent of Total



Normalize each bar to **100%** to compare the **mix** directly.

- Manhattan is **pedestrian and cyclist** heavy
- Staten Island is almost all **vehicle only**

```
shares = pd.crosstab(  
    df["borough"],  
    df["type"],  
    normalize="index",  
)  
shares.plot(kind="bar", stacked=True)
```

(Invented data, not real.)

Follow Up: Disaggregation

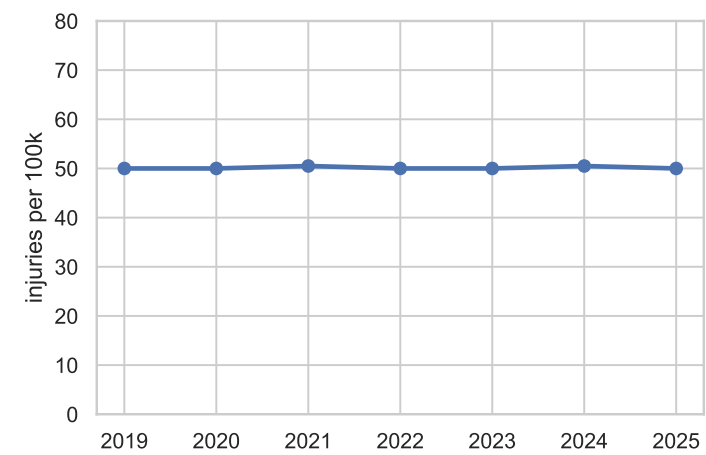
Disaggregation: break a total apart into meaningful subgroups instead of reporting one number.

- A single average is often **nobody's** experience: it hides the groups inside it
- We have been doing this: citywide accidents, split **by borough**, then **by type**
- Break down by whatever the question needs: **age, income, time of day, neighborhood**

Disaggregating helps us **understand the data more deeply** than any single total can.

Disaggregating Changes the Story

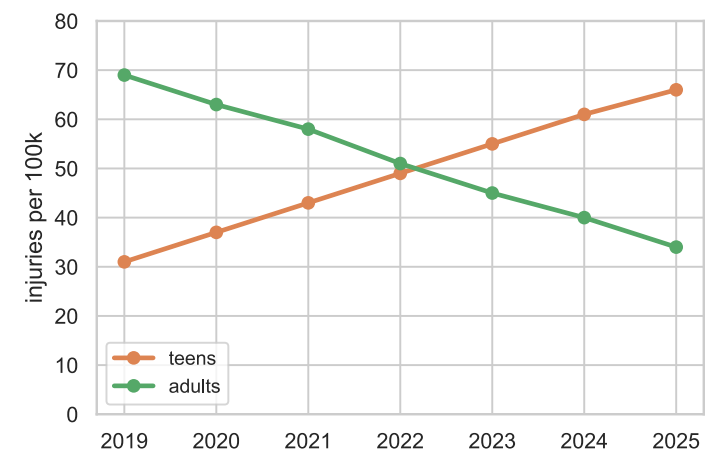
Aggregated



Citywide, the rate looks **flat**. Nothing to see.

(Invented data, not real.)

Disaggregated by age



Teens **rising**, adults **falling**. The total hid both.

Follow Up: Stay Skeptical

Having a dataset is not the same as having an **answer**. Good scientists are **skeptical**, especially of their own first read.

- Do not rush to a conclusion just because you have data
- Ask what **context** or **other variables** are missing
- This matters most with **real-world data**, which is always partial
- A finding usually **raises more questions** than it settles

The honest loop: a **question** and some **data** lead to **better questions**.

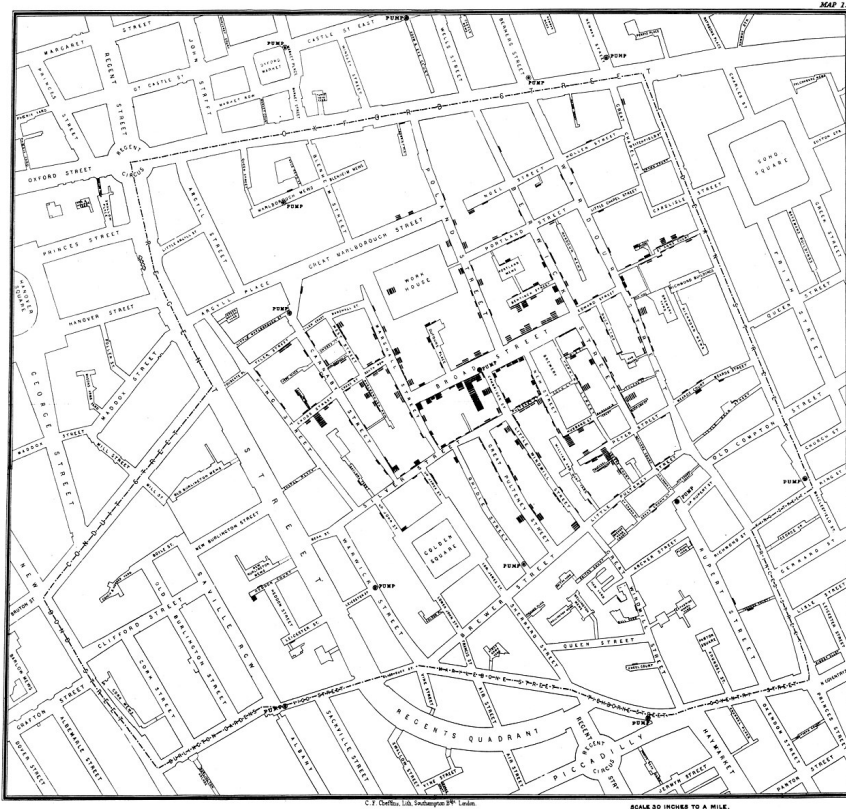
Follow Up: Data Science and Public Health

Public health runs on data science. Much of what we did today is how epidemiologists work every day.

- **Surveillance:** track cases across time and place (COVID and flu dashboards)
- **Risk factors:** link exposures to outcomes (smoking and lung cancer, air and asthma)
- **Disparities:** disaggregate by race, income, or ZIP to find who is underserved
- **Rates:** age-adjusted deaths per 100,000, not raw counts

And the field's founding moment was itself a **data visualization**.

The First Data Map: John Snow, 1854



Cholera was killing **Soho, London**. Snow plotted each death on a street map.

- Deaths **clustered** at one pump: **Broad Street**
- That meant **contaminated water**, not "bad air"
- Invisible in a table, obvious on a **map**

It helped launch modern **epidemiology**.

(Public domain, John Snow, 1854.)

Follow Up: Speak the Language

Using the **right terminology** is not pedantry. It is a **social signal**.

- Jargon is a **shibboleth**: an inside-group marker that says "I am one of you"
- Meeting someone in the field, or in a **job interview**, the right word builds an **instant connection**
- It shows you "**know ball**": that you have done the real work, not just read about it
- A vague or wrong word quietly signals the opposite

This is why we are picky about **terminology** on these slides, and in our discussions. Learn the words, and use them **confidently** and **naturally**: forced or hesitant jargon undercuts the effect.

Reports and Dashboards

Two ways to deliver what you found.

- A **report** tells **one story**, start to finish: fixed and curated, like a document or a slide deck
- A **dashboard** lets the reader **explore**: interactive, filterable, and always current

Same data, two very different deliverables. The right choice depends on your **audience** and their **question**.

Reports vs Dashboards

	Report	Dashboard
Shape	a fixed narrative	an interactive view
Who steers	you tell the story	the reader picks the path
Reader needs	only to read it	some skill to drive it
Freshness	a snapshot in time	updates with the data
Best for	a decision or conclusion	exploration and monitoring
Main risk	it goes stale	the reader can mislead themselves
Effort	write it once	build it, then maintain it

Where You See Each

Reports

- A quarterly PDF, a research paper, an analysis notebook, a slide deck

Dashboards

- A COVID case tracker, a Tableau or Power BI board, a Streamlit app, the NYC 311 map

Notice the pattern: dashboards tend to win when data is **critical and timely**. A quarterly PDF, or a study that takes **months or years** to publish, is too slow to act on.

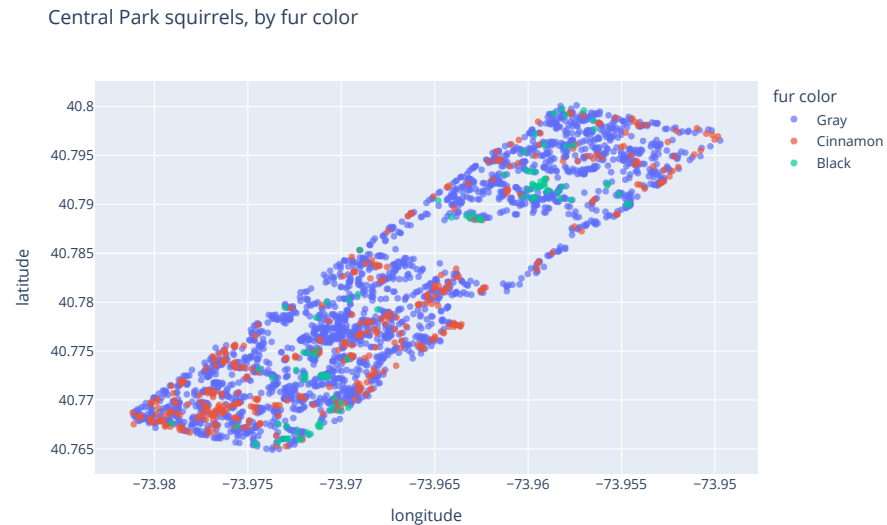
Meet Plotly

Plotly makes **interactive** charts in Python (and JavaScript).

- Charts are **interactive by default**: hover, zoom, pan, toggle series
- `plotly.express` (`px`) is the high-level API, one-liners like seaborn
- Renders in a **notebook** or exports to a standalone **web page**
- The natural fit for **dashboards**, where seaborn fits **reports**

```
import plotly.express as px  
  
px.scatter(df, x="x", y="y", color="fur_color")
```

Plotly: A Map of Squirrels



(Real data: 2018 Squirrel Census.)

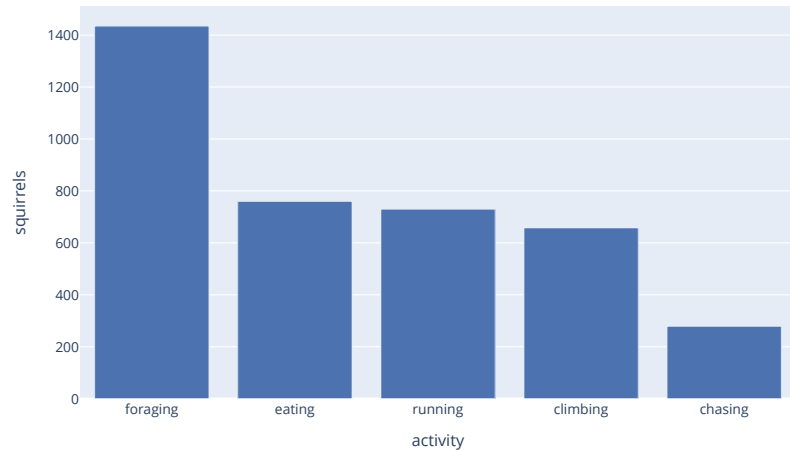
Each squirrel has an `x` and `y`, so plotting them draws **Central Park**.

```
px.scatter(  
    df, x="x", y="y",  
    color="primary_fur_color",  
)
```

Live, you can **hover** any point and **zoom** into any corner.

Plotly: Same Idea, Any Chart

What are the squirrels doing?



(Real data: 2018 Squirrel Census.)

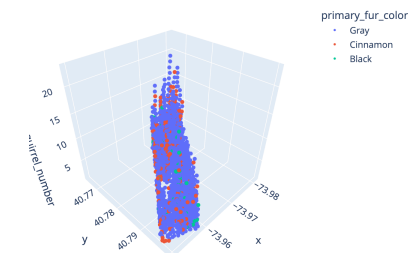
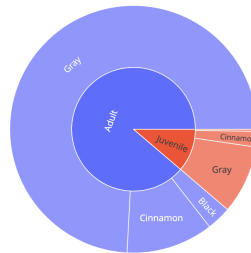
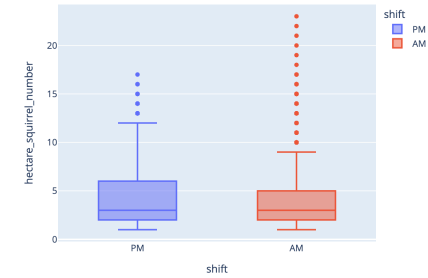
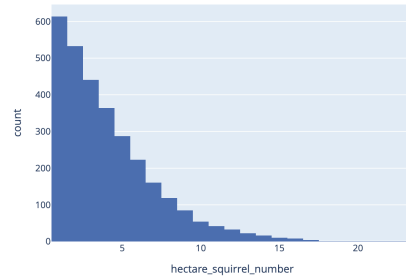
Same `px` pattern, different chart:

```
px.bar(  
    counts,  
    x="activity", y="squirrels",  
)
```

What plotly adds over a static image:

- **Hover** for exact values
- **Zoom** and **pan**
- **Click a legend entry** to hide a series

Plotly: A Whole Gallery



Dozens of chart types, including **hierarchical** and **3D** views you can rotate. Browse them all in the [official Plotly gallery](#).

(Real data: 2018 Squirrel Census.)

Demo: Interactive Charts with Plotly

Open `demos/plotly-intro/plotly_intro.ipynb` and **run it** to feel the difference.

- A **map** of the squirrels you can hover and zoom
- The same chart recolored by **age**, with one changed argument
- Exporting a figure to a standalone **web page** with `write_html`

Static on GitHub, **interactive** when you run it in Jupyter.

Group Project: Data for a Better NYC

Teams of 2. Use data to propose a change that would improve life for NYC residents.

- Use **at least two datasets**; at least one from [NYC Open Data](#)
- The datasets must **work together**: merged, compared, or one giving context (like population for rates)
- Deliver a report-style **Jupyter notebook** (markdown and visualizations) and a **presentation**
- **Due 2026-07-21**: you present your findings in class

Full spec: `project_specs/data-for-a-better-nyc.md`

Today's Exit Ticket

- [] Explain **copy by reference** vs **copy by value** (`df2 = df` vs `df.copy()`)
- [] Explain why a **raw count** can mislead, and use a **rate** instead
- [] **Disaggregate** a total to surface a pattern the aggregate hides
- [] Compare a **report** and a **dashboard**, and say when each fits
- [] Make an interactive chart with **Plotly**
- [] Use the **right terminology** confidently when talking about your work